



United Nations
Educational, Scientific and
Cultural Organization

Windhoek Office Newsletter

UNESCO Windhoek Office Newsletter

Issue 14, June 2016

Editorial

The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) Windhoek Office implemented several key activities during the month of June 2016.



The major highlight was the Validation Workshop on the findings of the scoping mission on education conducted in April on June 20th and 21st. The newly established Ministry of Higher Education, Training, and Innovation (MHETI) called upon UNESCO to conduct an evaluation that would assess the current status of technical and vocational education and training, higher education, and innovation in Namibia.

Also, the National Planning Commission (NPC), Ministry of International Relations and Cooperation (MIRCO) with the support of the United Nations (UN) in Namibia launched the Domestication of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and Africa Agenda 2063 on 8 June 2016.

The Ministry of Education Arts and Culture in collaboration with a number of UN agencies (UNDP, UNESCO, UNFPA, UNIC, UNICEF and WHO) and the Turkish Cooperation and Coordination Agency (TIKA) organised a landmark national consultative conference on school drop-out and out-of-school children.

The University of Namibia Environmental Society (UNES) invited UNESCO to partake in a panel discussion under the topic 'Protection for Wildlife in Namibia' as part of celebrating world environmental day.

The "Empowering Local Radios with ICTs" project sponsored by UNESCO and Swedish International Development Cooperation Agency (SIDA) came to an end.

The reflection of the month is about National Communication for Development Policies in Africa.

Our Invitee of the Month is Ms Ruusa Mushimba, the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) National Project Coordinator For Namibia.

Enjoy your reading!

Your comments and feedback are greatly appreciated.

Please contact: jp.ilboudo@unesco.org

Farewell Chimbidzikai Mapfumo



Mr Chimbidzikai Mapfumo, Former Chief Editor of the UNESCO Windhoek Newsletter. © Gail Fletcher/UNESCO

The UNESCO Windhoek Office would like to announce the departure of Mr Chimbidzikai Mapfumo who served as the Head of the Communications and Information Sector and the Chief Editor to the office's monthly newsletter. His final day in the office was on June 24th. His main activity was coordinating the SIDA Project "Empowering Local Radios with ICT's" where he covered Namibia, Lesotho and South Africa.

For over two years, he played an active and integral role in furthering UNESCO's mission to build knowledge societies and foster freedom of expression both locally and regionally. He will be missed by all of those in the office and we wish him the best in his future endeavours.

UNESCO welcomes new colleagues to the office

We would like to welcome Ms. Lealani van Wyk as Secretarial Assistant to the Head of Office. Ms. Van Wyk is a Certified Executive Personal Assistant and a member of the International Academy of Business and Financial Management.

She is a proactive, highly skilled professional, offering 14 years of Administrative and Secretarial experience and has over the years delivered professional support to Executives in diverse office environments.

She was previously employed in the Telecommunications, Insurance, FMCG, Asset Management and Financial Regulatory fields.

She describes herself as an enthusiastic self-starter and someone who approaches each new challenge with a fundamental flair for innovation.

She brings a wealth of experience and skills set, including creative problem-solving, multitasking and perseverance to task completion, as well as great organisational and streamlining skills.

Lealani is a Namibian citizen and mother of two daughters.

For further enquiries contact her at:

I.van-wyk@unesco.org



We would like to welcome Mr. Jakob Motinga who is the new Administrative Assistant for UNESCO Windhoek Office.

Mr. Motinga has previous experience working for the United Nations (UN) system in Namibia. He is also known to some of the UN staff members through his employment with United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR).

Mr. Motinga brings along over ten years of experience in the donor funded environment through his employment with UNHCR and the Catholic Aids Action.

He has been a civil servant for three years through his employment with the Auditor General's Office.

Additionally, he worked in the private sector for PricewaterhouseCoopers (PWC) and OB' Davids Properties, in finance.

Mr Motinga studied Accounting Science and Econometrics at undergraduate level.

For further enquiries contact him at:

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UNESCO scoping mission validation workshop on higher education, TVET and innovation a success



From left: Jerry Beukes, Hon. (Dr.) Becky Njoze-Ojo, Hon. (Dr.) Itah Kandjii-Murangi, Kiki Gbeho, Dr Jean Pierre Ilboudo, Borhene Chakroun, Charles Kabajani. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

HEAD OF OFFICE

The Validation Workshop on the findings of the scoping mission on education conducted in April was held in Windhoek on June 20th and 21st. The newly established Ministry of Higher Education, Training, and Innovation (MHETI) called upon the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) to conduct an evaluation that would assess the current status of technical and vocational education and training (TVET), higher education, and innovation in Namibia. The Ministry asked UNESCO to also “identify strategic priorities [for education] and

offer alternative interventions responding to those priorities”.

Hon. Itah Kandjii-Murangi, Minister of MHETI, requested assistance in developing policies and programs related to the three pillars of the Ministry’s mandate. The scoping mission was tasked to pay particular attention to “the contribution of public policies under the overall development goals such as poverty reduction, and to the implementation of key policy documents such as Namibia’s Vision 2030, National Development Plan 4 and 5, and the Harambee Prosperity Plan”.

UNESCO organized a team of technical experts comprised of three representatives from UNESCO headquarters (Borhene Chakroun, Francois Leclercq, Hassmik Tortian), two representatives from UNESCO Harare Office (Carolyn Medel-Anonuevo and Peggy Oti-Boateng), two external experts (John Ouma-Mugabe and Mayunga Nkunya) and an ILO expert (Naomy Lintini).

The goal of the workshop was to disseminate the findings of the scoping mission to stakeholders responsible for TVET, higher education, and —

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Hon. Itah Kandjii-Murangi addressing the audience about the current status of TVET in Namibia. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

UNESCO scoping mission validation workshop on higher education, TVET and innovation a success



Hon. Marlene Mungunda engaging the Scoping Mission during a panel discussion. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

it suffers from issues whose effects permeate throughout society. Namibia's economy is characterized by the "weight of the primary sector and the weakness of manufacturing industries." There is little diversification of the economy as Namibia has remained dependent upon only a few primary industries such as commercial farming, fisheries, and mining.

What has resulted from this reliance on the primary sector is a dual labor market in which most workers are employed in low-skilled jobs in subsistence farming, construction, trade,

or by private households while the remaining few are employed in high-skilled jobs in the formal economy. Moreover, unemployment remains high especially amongst women. To increase the demand of skilled workers in Namibia, entrepreneurship must be jumpstarted.

Despite being supported by high levels of public expenditure (far higher than the international benchmark), the education system has failed to produce results reflective of the support it has been given. The education system does not provide students with "a strong enough foundation" for a future in vocational education and training, higher education, and innovative activities. Basic education should act as a bridge to vocational training but its inadequacies remain a barrier that trainees must overcome.

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innovation as well as to engage in a series of discussions regarding each of the three sectors. The importance of education was emphasized throughout the workshop. In his address to stakeholders, Dr. Jean-Pierre Ilboudo, Head of Office at UNESCO Windhoek, described education as "indispensable for people to realize their capacities" and "the catalyst for development".

Dr. Borhene Chakroun, TVET Section Chief of UNESCO and Head of the scoping mission, presented a preliminary report of the scoping mission. In his presentation, he detailed key findings of the analysis. Beginning with an overview of a country context, Dr. Chakroun spoke of the rampant inequality in Namibia that has led to the perpetuation of poverty and unemployment in the country.

He then went on to further discuss the pressing issues that hamper the policy making process and Namibia's development including, a lack of water availability, a low population density, and an HIV/AIDS epidemic. The sustained growth and urbanization of youth is another demographic challenge Namibia must face. The vitality of policy implementation was thus stressed as Namibia must find a mechanism to meet the demands of young people for jobs.

The report also narrowed in on economic issues in the country. While Namibia's upper middle income economy is marked by stability and competitiveness,



Dr. Jean-Pierre Ilboudo, UNESCO Head of Office addressing the audience about UNESCO's role in promoting TVET in Namibia. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

UNESCO scoping mission validation workshop on higher education, TVET and innovation a success



Dr. Borhene Chakroun, TVET Section Chief of UNESCO and Head of the scoping mission, presented a preliminary report of the scoping mission. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

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Although it has been described as being sophisticated, Namibia's vocational and training system (VET) suffers from a series of issues that cause the system to churn out only a small amount of skilled workers. The system does not have the resources to enrol a sufficient number of trainees.

Trainees enrolled in the system are confronted with challenges such as untrained teachers and deficient equipment at training centers. At times, they are faced with difficult living conditions which impede their full attention in the classroom. Vocational training also "does not guarantee a smooth transition to employment or to entrepreneurship".

Following evaluation of VET, higher education, and innovation in Namibia, the team of experts stated the MHETI must "improve policy implementation, by aligning policy design, oversight and service delivery, and developing monitoring and evaluation, orient policies towards employment and sustainable development, expand work-based learning, removing barriers to innovation and entrepreneurship, and engaging enterprises in skills formation, innovation and jobs creation, and address inequality".

The importance of strengthening the relationship between VET and the private sector was stressed. Improved relations can ensure a better transition from vocational training and education to the workforce. The team concluded that the "governance and financing of VET should be revised for maximum efficiency".

In the field of higher education and innovation issues also lie. Namibian students perform poorly in STEM fields. This proves to be an impediment to innovation in the country. There is also little focus on employment and entrepreneurship.

The team offer policies the Ministry should consider as they move forward with their improvements to education in Namibia. The priorities given are to:

- Transform and expand VET and diversify higher education
- Improve quality
- Enhance responsiveness to labor market needs
- Promote research, innovation and entrepreneurship
- Reduce inequality in education and training
- Fill policy gaps and review the institutional structure.

The validation workshop offered an opportunity for stakeholders to learn more about the current state of education in Namibia, to list their grievances, and to offer suggestions for the future of the systems.

The content of the debates will be reflected in a final report by UNESCO that will be used by the Ministry to improve their approach to education. The report will be finalized by July 2016.



Prof. John Mugabe, one of the members from the UNESCO scoping mission briefing the participants about their findings. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

Namibia launches domestication of Sustainable Development Goals and Africa Agenda 2063



Official delegates standing together in solidarity during the national launch of the SDGs and Africa Agenda 2063.
© Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

Speaking at the launch, Namibia's Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of International Relations and Cooperation, Hon. Netumbo Nandi-Ndaitwah said it is important to understand the synergies between the two development frameworks and their relevance to national development agendas.

"As the two agendas complement each other, they provide an opportunity for implementation, without unduly burdening policy-

makers with multiple development frameworks, monitoring and evaluation mechanisms, and reporting obligations, while at the same time reducing coordination challenges," she said.

She noted that the vision of Africa expressed in Agenda 2063 is one of an Africa whose development is people-driven, especially relying on the potential offered by its women and youth.

"Women empowerment remains critical for the effective implementation of the two agendas. The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, asserts that gender equality is not only a human right, but a necessary foundation for a peaceful and inclusive world" said the minister.

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The National Planning Commission (NPC), Ministry of International Relations and Cooperation (MIRCO) with the support of the United Nations (UN) in Namibia launched the Domestication of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and Africa Agenda 2063 on 8 June 2016. The well attended event was held in Windhoek at the Parliament Conference Hall.

The National Launch aims to kick-start the popularization of not only the SDGs but also the Africa Agenda 2063. The launch was a follow up of an SDG workshop which took place in Swakopmund in November 2015 lead by NPC with participants pulled mainly from the UN development system, Ministry of International Relations and Cooperation and important delegates from the key sectors of education, health, agriculture, trade and industry, fisheries and marine resources, to mention but a few.

The Deputy Prime Minister, Honourable (Hon.) Netumbo Nandi-Ndaitwah, Minister of Economic Planning, Hon. Tom Alweendo and the UN Resident Coordinator to Namibia, Ms Kiki Gbeho led a panel discussion, followed by an interactive session with the audience.

The private sector, civil society, academia, representatives from the EU and many other development partners came out in numbers, and participated actively throughout the discourse.



The Deputy Prime Minister, Honourable (Hon.) Netumbo Nandi-Ndaitwah during the official launch of the domestication of the SDGs and Africa Agenda 20163. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

Namibia launches domestication of Sustainable Development Goals and Africa Agenda 2063

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She also urged that women and girls must not be left behind when it comes to education, decent work, equitable wages, and decision-making at all levels of government and should be fully accommodated in the two development agendas.

Director General of the National Planning Commission, Tom Alweendo, who serves as the representative of the Namibian President on the high-level committee of the African Union on the post-2015 Development Agenda, played an essential role in the formulation and adoption of the 17 SDGs.

During the panel discussion, the UN RC for Namibia, Ms Gbeho mentioned that there is a significant need to embrace development partnerships, which are important vehicles for leveraging new resources, co-operation and innovations.



Ms Kiki Gbeho, UN Resident Coordinator was part of the panel at the launch. © Joseph lilonga/ UNESCO

“Partnerships will allow for an engagement with a much wider array of actors whose skills and knowledge could assist us to deliver on our development objectives” said the UN RC.

The launch was broadcast live on National Radio, and eight community radio stations from different regions around the country reported live in their respective vernaculars.

The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) were designed to address root causes of poverty and the universal need for development that works for all. Each of the 17 goals has 169 targets, of which those targets have 230 indicators.

The implementation of Agenda 2063 will be carried out through five Ten-Year Implementation Plans, which are to be integrated into National Development Plans alongside the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).



Deputy minister in the Presidency Alexia Manombe-Ncube sharing her view during the panel discussion. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

Khomas Youth Health Task Force Launched



Some members of the youth from Khomas region came to support the launch of the Khomas Youth Health Task Force.

Stakeholders from Government, civil society including young people from different schools across Khomas region and youth-led/serving organizations and development partners came together to officially launch the Khomas Youth Health Task Force in line with the ESA Ministerial Commitment objectives.

The Task Force is a new partnership targeting the health of the youth in the Khomas region. The youth led initiative is a critical step towards reducing teenage pregnancies, alcohol and drug abuse, gender based violence and eliminating all new HIV infections among young people by 2020 in the Khomas Region.

Honorable Rosalia Sibiya who is the Special Advisor to the Khomas Governor welcomed the stakeholders on behalf of the Khomas Governor. In her remarks, she noted that young people are the future for each nation and therefore there is a need to address the challenges facing them.

The Permanent Secretary (PS) of the Ministry of Education Arts and Culture, Ms. Sanet Steenkamp officially launched the Khomas Youth Health Task Force under the theme: "Teamwork Makes the Dream Work: Our Health Matters".

She called for the provision of a comprehensive sexuality education which is culturally sensitive and age

appropriate to enable learners and young people to make informed sexual decisions. The PS also called for greater support to address the high levels of teenage pregnancies and low levels of comprehensive HIV knowledge among young people.

"More than 50% of our youth do not have sufficient knowledge on HIV", she said.

The PS further noted that the Khomas Youth Health Taskforce is a realization of a good functioning coordination body and implementation of the ESA ministerial commitment on the regional level.

She mentioned that according to her experience the Taskforce does not need a lot of resources but rather a common vision and strong commitment towards the shared aim.

Ms. Sanet Steenkamp ended her speech with some very logical words to all the people who were in the room and all those throughout the region.

"You are a key part of this health campaign, every person who joins this campaign, who likes it and shares it, will bring our dream for the youth of Khomas that much closer to reality," she said.



From Right: Honorable Rosalia Sibiya, the Special Advisor to the Khomas Governor sitting next to the Director of Khomas Education, Arts and Culture, Mr Gerard Vries and the Permanent Secretary of Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture, Ms. Sanet Steenkamp before she delivered the Khomas Region Governor's speech.

Namibia hosts National conference on school drop-out and out-of-school children



A young student reciting an inspirational poem about children without education. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

In her remarks as the UN residence Coordinator, Ms. Kiki Gbeho indicated that Namibia has made progress in universal primary education as almost 99% of children are going to school.

However, dropping out remains a problem in the secondary phase. She further reiterated the commitment of the UN to remain the “partner of choice” to the Namibian government and pledged the UN support to work collectively with other stakeholders to find lasting solutions to the problem of out-of-

school youth.

When sharing the guest speaker remarks on behalf of the Deputy Prime Minister Honorable (Hon) Netumbo Nandi-Ndaitwah, the Deputy Minister of International Relations and Cooperation Hon Peya Mushelenga, indicated the importance of taking care of the out-of-school children and bringing them back into education while ensuring that no one is left behind.

He further alluded to the fact that government needs accurate information on the out-of-school children in order to effect change and facilitate policy making.

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The Ministry of Education Arts and Culture in collaboration with a number of UN agencies (UNDP, UNESCO, UNFPA, UNIC, UNICEF and WHO) and the Turkish Cooperation and Coordination Agency (TIKA) organised a landmark national consultative conference on school drop-out and out-of-school children. The conference was held from 23 to 24 June at the Windhoek Country Club and Resort.

Since 2010, the United Nations Children's Emergency Fund (UNICEF) and United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) Institute of Statistics (UIS) have been working with governments worldwide to address the challenges of out-of-school children or those who are at risk of dropping out. In 2015 Namibia joined more than 50 countries to complete a report on children who are at risk of dropping out of school or who have dropped out of school.

This conference focused on exploring a few key questions including why children are dropping out of school; who the out-of-school children are; who is at risk of not going to school and or dropping out; and what we can do to prevent this or ensure that children return to some form of education. The conference also concluded some recommendations and strategies on how to mitigate school dropout to be shared with the Ministry of Education Arts and Culture to spearhead further action.



From left: Mrs. Micaela Marques De Sousa (UNICEF), Dr Jean Pierre Ilboudo (UNESCO) and Ambassador of Turkey to Namibia, H.E Deniz Çakar at the School drop-out and out-of-school children conference.

© Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

Namibia hosts National conference on school drop-out and out-of-school children



Ms Kiki Gbeho (UN Resident Coordinator) addressing the audience during the school drop-out and out-of-school children conference in Windhoek. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

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While recognizing that Namibia's policies are aligned well with international standards, he indicated the need for continued engagement in inter-sectoral dialogue.

In her keynote remarks and launch of the Out-of-School National review, the Minister of Education Arts and Culture Hon Katrina Hanse-Himarwa, underscored the importance of literacy as a "human right and the basis for lifelong learning".

She further alluded to the fact that it "empowers individuals, families and communities and improves their quality of life". Because of its "multiplier effect", literacy helps eradicate poverty, reduce child mortality, curb population growth, achieve gender equality and ensure sustainable development, peace and democracy.

She went on to indicate that in today's rapidly-changing, knowledge based societies where social and political participation takes place both physically and virtually, acquisition of basic literacy skills and the advancement and application of such skills throughout life is crucial. Hence the need for children to stay in school and complete the full cycle of schooling.

Once available, the workshop recommendations and key resolutions will be shared broadly with all the key stakeholders for further action.

The idea of the conference emanated from an enquiry by Hon. Netumbo Nandi-Ndaitwah during the presentation of UNESCO Head of Office, Dr Jean Pierre Ilboudo's credentials.

TIKA Head of Department, External Affairs and Partnerships, Dr Mehmet Yilmaz. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO



Ohangwena Directorate of Education Arts and Culture launches SDG 4



(Front row ,left) Mrs. Micaela Marques De Sousa, UNICEF Country Representative and Dr Jean Pierre Ilboudo, UNESCO Country Representative (Back row, right) pledging their support at the regional launch of SDG 4 in Eenhana, Namibia.

The Ohangwena Regional Council-Directorate of Education Arts and Culture and regional stakeholders including, circuit inspectors, school principals, teachers, office of the governor, line ministries, United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) and the United Nations Children's Emergency Fund (UNICEF) came together on 28th June 2016 in Eenhana to launch the 4th Sustainable Development Goal (SDG 4) at regional level. The thematic goal for SDG 4 is "Towards inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all".

The launch was a follow up to the national launch of SDG4 by the Minister of Education Arts and Culture on 25 April 2016 in Windhoek and aimed at sensitizing and gaining support from key stakeholders to ensure provision of inclusive, equitable and quality education.

Mr. Isak Hamatui, director of Education in the Ohangwena Region thanked and welcomed the participants. His remarks highlighted the regional progress and achievements made with regard to ensuring access to inclusive and quality education. These includes building of 10 primary schools, introduction of pre-primary classes at 182 junior primary, senior -

primary and combined schools; building of libraries, laboratories, and teachers houses as well as expansion of literacy classes across the region.

He urged the school principals to familiarize themselves with the Targets of SDG4 and to share them with their teachers, learners and parents during meetings.

Speaking at the same occasion UNICEF Country Representative, Mrs. Micaela Marques De Sousa, applauded the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture for taking the lead to launch the SDG 4. She noted that sustainable development begins with education and it should start at home.

"Learning services should be combined with strong family support, access to health services, good nutrition and a responsive protection system" she said.

Mrs. De Sousa acknowledged the greater achievements Namibia has made, especially in primary education enrolment and Namibia being ranked third on the Education for All Development Index.

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Ohangwena Directorate of Education Arts and Culture launches SDG 4

GOAL 4



ENSURE INCLUSIVE AND EQUITABLE QUALITY
EDUCATION AND PROMOTE LIFELONG LEARNING
OPPORTUNITIES FOR ALL

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Despite the achievements, she remarked that there are still challenges and barriers that keep children out of school and these need urgent action to ensure that all boys and girls go through quality early childhood development programmes, complete free quality primary and secondary education as well as vocational and tertiary education.

She reassured UNICEF's commitment to work with and support the government of Namibia through the Ministry of Education Arts and Culture and other stakeholders, to heed the call of the SDGs and SDG4 in particular.

Dr. Jean Pierre Ilboudo, the UNESCO country representative, emphasized on the importance of skills development, Higher education and technical and vocational education in relation to Targets 3 to 7 of SDG4. He started his remarks with a quote by United Nations (UN) Secretary General (SG), Mr. Ban Ki-Moon.

"Education is a fundamental right and the basis for progress in every country. Parents need information about health and nutrition if they are to give their children the start in life they deserve. Prosperous countries depend on skilled and educated workers. The challenges of conquering poverty, combatting climate change and achieving truly sustainable development in the coming decades compel us to work together. With partnership, leadership and wise investments in education, we can transform individual lives, national economies and our world," said the SG.

Dr. Ilboudo remarked that education is a catalyst for development and further noted that Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET), Higher -

Education and Science, Technology and Innovation (STI) systems need to address multiple demands of an economic, social and environmental nature by equipping youth and adults with the skills and confidence they need for employment, decent work and entrepreneurship.

He further noted that higher education must be inclusive and equitable for every citizen to have access to quality education and lifelong learning opportunities. Dr. Ilboudo emphasised the importance of incorporating technology and innovation into the mainstream education system for positive transformation.

He highlighted the strides made by UNESCO Windhoek office in different thematic areas in support of government efforts to achieve quality and equitable education which includes; the use of information and communication technology in Education, TVET, addressing school-drop outs; Education for Sustainable Development; Comprehensive Sexuality Education and Human Rights Education.

He concluded by emphasizing the importance of lifelong learning and encouraged students to continue learning, strive for academic excellence and gain more and more skills and knowledge.

The advisor to the Ohangwena Governor, Retired General Peter Nambundunga officially launched the SDG 4 on behalf of the Regional Governor. He remarked that Ohangwena region is committed to contribute to the achievement of Goal 4 and ensures that learners from all walks of life in the region have access to quality education. He applauded the Government of the Republic of Namibia for the current investment of twelve billion Namibia Dollars (N\$) which is currently the biggest allocation from the National budget to the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture.

He called for further additional funding to support the Ohangwena Directorate of Education, Arts and Culture, and the schools in their attempts to realize vision 2030. The retired general called on the UN agencies such as UNICEF and UNESCO to continue supporting the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture and urged school principals and teachers who are at the critical level of implementation to ensure that the targets of SDG 4 are achieved.

Geosciences Information for Teachers (GIFT) workshop in Vienna, Austria: A teachers' journey to greater science



Teachers at the GIFT workshop learning about geosciences.

During the workshop the teachers presented posters on their classroom activities. Lileka-Shinavene's poster was titled 'Science in and out of the classroom: A look at water resources at Gammas Water Care Works, Windhoek, Namibia'.

The workshop was an eye-opening experience for Lileka-Shinavene as she gained some new ideas which she plans to try in her classes and share with her fellow teachers. She hopes that more Namibian science teachers will participate in the GIFT workshop in the near future.

The next GIFT workshop will be at the 35th International Geological Congress (IGC) in Cape Town, South Africa on 27-28 August. Talks on natural resources and natural hazards will be presented along with hands-on exercises. Teachers are encouraged by the organisers Dr. Carlo Laj and Dr. Friedrich Barnikel (EGU Committee on Education) to apply.

A three day workshop on Geosciences Information for Teachers (GIFT) with the theme "The Solar System and Beyond" was held in Vienna, Austria during the General Assembly of the European Geosciences Union (EGU) in April 2016. EGU takes place annually and this year 13 650 delegates from 109 countries attended the conference.

Leena Mpingana lileka-Shinavene, a teacher at the Van Rhyn Primary School in Windhoek had an opportunity to participate in the GIFT workshop. Since 2003 the EGU Committee on Education has organised the GIFT workshop, which is open to all school teachers, under different scientific themes.

The main aim of these workshops is to enable teachers from various countries to learn about geosciences through interactions with scientists and share various methods on teaching science in school through theory and hands-on activities.

The workshop was attended by 81 teachers from 22 countries mostly from Europe and America. Only two of the teachers were from Africa - Malawi and Namibia. This was the first time a Namibian teacher participated in the GIFT workshop. In line with the theme, several prominent scientists gave talks centered on the solar system. Apart from the workshop teachers had access to the work of many scientists at EGU through presentations, both poster and oral.



Leena presenting her work to a delegate at the GIFT workshop

About Leena Mpingana lileka-Shinavene

Leena Mpingana lileka-Shinavene is a science teacher at Van Rhyn Primary School. Since 2003 she has taught Natural Sciences to grade 5, 6 and 7 pupils. Her pupils regularly participate in out-of-the classroom science activities such as science fairs and trips. She is on the lookout for new ways to teach science in the classroom.

lileka-Shinavene's trip to the GIFT workshop was supported by the EGU and Ministry of Education.

UNESCO assists Directorate of Heritage and Culture to plan for the future



Some of the participants from the Directorate of Heritage and Culture Programme in the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture at the workshop in Swakopmund.

CULTURE

The Directorate of Heritage and Culture Programme in the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture invited the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) to deliver a presentation on Cultural Heritage as a driver to sustainable economic prosperity at their Annual Planning workshop in Swakopmund held from 06-09 June 2016.

Mr. Boyson Ngondo and UNESCO Head of Office (HoO), Dr. Jean Pierre Ilboudo delivered a joint presentation on the topic: "Cultural Heritage as a driver to sustainable economic prosperity". The presentation was divided in three parts, Dr. Ilboudo started with a historical perspective on the role of culture for sustainable development while Mr. Ngondo then continued by focusing on the contemporary discourse around this topic from UNESCO's perspective.

Dr. Ilboudo then gave the way forward mentioning a list of possible interventions for the Ministry in their next Medium Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF) as well as for the next financial year's annual work plans.

During his presentation, the UNESCO HoO indicated that there is a significant paradigm shift regarding how culture is viewed today in relation to development and how the process of globalization is transforming all societies and bringing culture urgently to the fore.

"There was a time when culture was not uttered in the same sentence with development. Culture was associated with traditions and customs that were sometimes seen as obstacles to

development or it was linked with elitist art and narrowly defined in scope. Culture was of the past, whereas development was for the future. At best, culture stood on the sidelines of development policies. At worst, it was viewed as retrograde," he said.

He further indicated that the United Nations (UN) Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) mark a substantial step forward as this is the first time in history that the international development agenda refers to culture within its framework. Goal 11 of the SDGs targets cities so that they are more inclusive, safe resilient and sustainable.

More precisely it refers to cities as hubs of culture among others such as commerce and science.

During his presentation, Mr. Ngondo also noted that there is a significant link between culture and development and how culture can play an important role in the fight against poverty.

"Culture is a key resource to address both the economic and social dimensions of poverty and to provide innovative and cross-cutting solutions to complex issues-- such as health and the environment, gender equality and promoting quality education for all. Today, cultural heritage, cultural and creative industries, sustainable cultural tourism, and cultural infrastructure generate substantial revenues, notably in developing countries thereby fighting poverty and unemployment," he said.

In his closing remarks, Dr. Ilboudo proposed measures that can build on culture's contribution to sustainable development. He urged the Government of the Republic of Namibia to effectively integrate culture in the conception, measurement, and practice of development with a view to advancing inclusive, equitable, and sustainable development.

The Africa Union in its Agenda 2063 also makes it clear that culture has a critical role to play in the development of the continent as expressed by Aspiration 5 - An Africa with a Strong Cultural Identity, Common Heritage, Values and Ethics. National development plans such as Vision 2030 and now the Harambee Prosperity Plan are all centered on economic and social prosperity and culture has a central role to play in realizing these noble ideas.

UNESCO participates in World Environmental Day



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Environmental
Protection
Authority
(KEPA), 2016

CULTURE

The University of Namibia Environmental Society (UNES) invited the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) to partake in a panel discussion under the topic 'Protection for Wildlife in Namibia' as part of celebrating world environmental day. The Environmental Day celebration was held at the University of Namibia's (UNAM) main campus on 3rd June 2016 under the international theme "Zero Tolerance for the Illegal Trade in Wildlife".

Mr. Boyson Ngondo, the Head of Culture Sector at UNESCO represented the office at the celebrations. He mentioned that UNESCO is playing a major role in the global efforts for wildlife conservation by enlisting important habitats for animals in the UNESCO World Heritage List.

"Since time immemorial, humanity has marvelled at the wild animals with which we co-exist and on which we depend. Prehistoric people have depicted wildlife through rock art and engravings, many of which are included in the UNESCO World Heritage List. UNESCO's global network of World Heritage sites and Biosphere Reserve are home to some of the most emblematic and threatened wildlife species, including mountain gorillas, pandas, tigers and different species of rhino," he said.

Mr. Ngondo also called upon all stakeholders including, government authorities, nongovernmental -

organizations, customs services, police forces and the scientific community to redouble their efforts and deepen cooperation. According to him only by joining forces can humanity craft a sustainable future for the planet's precious wildlife and biodiversity.

"In our view, wildlife conservation is the practice of protecting wild plant and animal species and their habitats. The goal of wildlife conservation is to ensure that nature will be around for future generations to enjoy and also to recognize the importance of wildlife and wilderness for humans and other species alike," he said.

UNES is a student run project which falls under the Office of the Student Representative Council Member for Culture. The society educates students on environmental issues and supports green causes such as celebrating Earth Hour on campus and many other activities including awareness driven projects such as clean up campaigns.

World Environmental Day is observed every year on 5 June and is the United Nations' most important day for uniting the world in recognizing the importance of the protection of the environment. UNESCO has participated in UNES activities before including the plant a tree campaign earlier this year.

Towards National Communication for Development Policies in Africa



Dr. Jean-Pierre Ilboudo,
Head of office, UNESCO, Windhoek

Why national policies?

To be effective, communication for development must be systematically planned, implemented and coordinated. In these days of structural adjustments governments must find solutions for greater cost effectiveness in all of their operations. In the field of development communication, there is need for more coordination and elimination of duplication of efforts. The existing situation in many countries where each sectoral ministry has its own development communication unit is no longer cost effective, and the lack of coordination often creates confusion, with the dissemination of conflicting messages to the rural population. National rural communication systems should be established to meet the needs of all the stakeholders and should work with ministries of agriculture, rural development, forestry, environment, women's affairs, social services, health, and information and communication, and other relevant ministries, drawing upon the resources of all the partners. Rural communication systems should not be limited to the public sector, but should encompass NGOs, universities and the private sector.

For all of these reasons, the definition of national communication for development policies are now high on the agenda of a number of countries in Africa and are the subject of policy and intellectual debate. The issues relate to how such policies can best reflect overall development priorities, and what sort of national communication system encourages people's participation, the sharing of knowledge and skills at all levels, and coordination of efforts among all partners involved in the development process. What sort of system can become income generating and sustainable? Other issues concern the need to regulate public and private ownership of the media used for rural development and participation, the amount of advertising and the extent of decentralisation allowed, as well as the regulation of new communication technologies such as telecommunications and electronic networks to make them accessible to rural people for development purposes. Clearly, each country will develop its own policy and or strategies in accordance with its economic, social, political, institutional and cultural framework, and the general communication policies, legislation and institutional frameworks already existing in the country.

Lessons learned on how to prepare a national policy

A number of countries in Africa are requesting the UN agencies (specially FAO's Communication for Development Service) to assist them in the definition of a national communication for development policy. The Governments of Mali and Guinea Bissau have been among the first to embark on the process and Central African Republic, the Congo, and Burkina Faso undertook similar exercises in 1996.

From 1998 to 2000, Niger and Burkina Faso were assisted in designing their national communication for development policies.

Although each country will develop its own model and approaches, there are certain commonalities and lessons that can be learned from these first experiences:

1) A national communication for development policy requires a socio-political and development environment that is conducive to participatory development. Is the society sufficiently open to dialogue with the rural people, sufficiently democratic for the processes initiated by communication for development to operate? If not, there is no use in attempting to define a national development communication policy or strategy.

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2) A national communication policy cannot and should not be an aim in itself. It should be formulated in accordance with the development priorities of each country. National development communication policies should complement other sectoral development policies and promote and support their objectives. Specialised communication strategies should be formulated for each technical sector and the content of communication messages must be provided by the different technical sectors and specialists.

3) There should be political support at the highest level, if once formulated, the policy is to be approved by the relevant government bodies and made operational. In the case of Mali, for example, the President himself felt that the people of Mali must assume responsibility for their own development and that a democratic process could not be achieved without the participation of the rural people, thus underlining the importance of communication. Accordingly, he asked FAO and UNDP to assist in the preparation and implementation of a national workshop to define a communication policy for development.

4) There should be a national focal point, with a secretariat to initiate the process. In the case of Mali and Guinea Bissau the Ministries of Information and Communication took the lead. Funds should be available to carry out the preliminary studies and organise the meetings required to define the policy. Donors may be interested in financing such an activity.

5) A series of preliminary studies are essential to provide the basic data and background information. These should include: identification of communication needs and priorities with the various stakeholders and in accordance with development priorities, identification of different audiences, survey of existing communication infrastructures and media suitable for development purposes (such as rural radio, television, rural press, video, traditional media, interpersonal communication, the potential, challenges and constraints for the use of new communication technologies such as telecommunications, electronics and digital technologies, etc.), a survey of existing development communication institutions, services and partners, both in the public, non-governmental and private sectors, and a survey of

existing qualified personnel available and requirements for further training. There should also be preliminary studies on existing communication governing bodies and legislation as well as alternative proposals for appropriate institutional frameworks to implement the national communication policy. All of these studies can be carried out by national consultants. However, it has proven useful to have a preliminary workshop to brief them on the exercise, provide them with guidelines for the studies and ensure that there is a common understanding on the role and functions of development communication.

6) It has also proven useful to organize preparatory meetings at regional or local level within the country and to validate the communication needs and priorities of different stakeholders, including farmer's associations, NGOs, and field workers. These workshops are also useful for advocacy and to brief the various stakeholders on the role and functions of communication for development.

7) Finally, a national workshop is essential to define the development communication policy as well as an action plan for its implementation. Past experience has confirmed that the national workshop should be attended by representatives of all the stakeholders involved. At the same time, participation should be limited to those who are really familiar with the various aspects of communication for development. In addition to the preliminary studies prepared by the national consultants, there should be a basic background/position paper summarising the main findings and recommendations of the studies for the definition of the policy and an action plan. This documentation should be made available well in advance to enable the participants to analyse the recommendations and alternatives. The results of the national workshop will also depend on the quality of the inputs made by the different preparatory meetings at the regional or local level.

8) The national workshop should define the role and functions of development communication, its objectives, different audiences and stakeholders, appropriate media channels and media to be applied, an appropriate institutional framework and coordinating mechanisms, any new legislation required, responsibilities for participating institutions, and requirements for training of national staff and training institutions.

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It should also approve an action plan with a time frame for the implementation of the national policy.

For example, both workshops in Mali and Guinea Bissau analysed existing media channels and structures, and constraints and made a series of recommendations to improve their potential for development purposes. These included: decentralisation of materials production, when appropriate, in the local languages and with the participation of the rural people; legislation to allow private sector institutions to develop and public sector institutions to have more autonomy and generate income; more coordination and integration between public sector and private sector activities. High on the list as media channels for use in rural areas were: rural radio, traditional media, audio-visual media, video, the rural press and face to face communication as a basis and an interface for all media.

Both workshops recommended upgrading the status of the profession of communication for development as well as training of specialists ranging from communication skills training for field workers to higher level academic training for communication planners and managers.

Institutional frameworks

With regard to the institutional framework, both workshops recommended:

a) The establishment of a high level intersectoral commission, for policy development, research, legislation and monitoring and evaluation. In the case of Mali, it was decided to establish an intersectoral coordinating committee under the "Conseil Supérieur de la Communication" the highest policy body dealing with communication in the country. In the case of Guinea Bissau, a similar coordinating committee was established within the Prime Minister's Office.

b) The establishment of an Executive Secretariat to supervise the implementation of the policy and action plan, and with coordinating functions. In Mali, a parastatal national development communication institution, CESP (Centre de Services de Production Audiovisuelle), was established as the focal point, while in Guinea Bissau an Executive Secretariat was established within the Ministry of Social Communication.

c) Individual sectors and ministries with existing development communication units will maintain responsibility for identifying sectoral communication needs, developing sectoral communication strategies and producing some communication materials for their own sector. They will also have responsibility for training of field staff in communication skills and the use of communication materials.

The action plan should envisage the necessary government actions required to make the policy operational, including legislation and financial provisions. In addition to developing national coordinating mechanisms, it is useful to foresee also coordinating the activities of donors to avoid duplication of efforts and ensure that all inputs to communication for development are in line with the national policy. In Mali, UNDP undertook efforts to coordinate inputs from multilateral and bi-lateral donors.

The workshops emphasised the need to carry out action research on different communication approaches as well as to develop monitoring and evaluation indicators and methodologies to assess the impact and cost effectiveness of different approaches. Documentation centres and databases should be established. Finally, both workshops recommended that all development projects and programmes include communication components, with the necessary resources to implement them.

Towards policies in other regions

The above are some of the lessons learned as a result of our first experiences in West Africa. We hope that they may be relevant also to countries in other regions as they move towards more systematic, coordinated and effective approaches to communication for development. It could be useful to foresee an exchange of experiences among countries within regions and possibly between regions through a series of workshops. One or more donors could be approached to provide support for the preparation of national communication for development policies, and for an exchange of experiences and lessons learned.

For more information please contact Dr Jean-Pierre Ilboudo, Head of Office, UNESCO, Windhoek
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UNESCO/Sida Project “Empowering Local Radios with ICTs” Concludes

Mr Lineekela Shikongo, Station Manager of Ohangwena Community Radio and Mr Hiskia Nashuta, a presenter and journalist at Live FM listening attentively during the SIDA Project closing ceremony at the UN House.
© Joseph lilonga/ UNESCO



The "Empowering Local Radios with ICTs" project sponsored by UNESCO and Swedish International Development Cooperation Agency (Sida) was developed with the overarching goal for radio stations to better serve their communities by improving access to information.

The capacity building project was geared towards improving the quality of programming in local radio stations, increasing programming on development issues, and giving more voice to lower income communities. Implementation of the project was focused in the Democratic Republic of Congo, Lesotho, Namibia, South Africa, Tanzania and Zambia and it began in 2012.

The project came at an important time in Namibia as the country lags behind other African countries in technological connectivity and suffers from a “data gap”. The project was a way to act upon the understanding that improving local radios can serve as one means towards achieving a stronger networked society.

At the closing ceremony for the project, station managers and other representatives from radio stations across Namibia came together in Windhoek to share what they had learned throughout the partnership and the impact the project had on their stations.

Final reports for the project for the seven countries were also reviewed at the event. Project coordinators reported many of the objectives for

“Empowering Local Radios” were achieved. Among the successes were the increase in the use of ICTs in targeted radios and the significant increase in gender-sensitive reporting.

The testimonies given by the radio stations at the concluding ceremony were reflective of the results from the overall evaluation for the project. There was a unanimous affirmation that, through various means of support, the program facilitated improvements at their stations and helped them to “share the stories of their communities”.

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Participants from various community radio stations in Namibia that benefited from the UNESCO/SIDA funded project came to support and share their experience. © Joseph lilonga/ UNESCO

UNESCO/Sida Project “Empowering Local Radios with ICTs” Concludes



Middle: Mr Chimbidzikai Mapfumo, the UNESCO Consultant and coordinator for the SIDA project presented certificates to the four main Radio Stations, Live FM, Base FM, Ohangwena Community Radio and NBC !ah radio.
© Joseph lilonga/ UNESCO

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UNESCO and Sida donated ICT equipment such as voice recorders, cell phones, flip cameras and computers to the stations which were instrumental in improving the quality of their center.

The donation of ICTs allowed the radio stations to better engage community members. Some radio stations created social media pages in an effort to further broaden their reach to local society.

The local stations developed programming intended to raise awareness about social issues such as teenage pregnancy, alcohol and drug abuse, early marri-

age and school drop-out. Some also held events intended to increase youth awareness of and involvement in the media.

Representatives stated that they benefited from the workshops and meetings on gender sensitivity in the media and financial management skills, and general skills for producing and presenting programs held by organizing partners.

Although the “Empowering Local Radios” project has concluded, the community radios asserted their desires to strengthen and build upon the foundation set by the project.

The participants were all ears during the presentations delivered by the representatives of each radio station at the closing ceremony.
© Joseph lilonga/ UNESCO



Community Radio Stations hail UNESCO and Swedish support



Participants from various community radio stations namely, Base FM (Windhoek), Live FM (Rehoboth), Ohangwena Community Radio (Eenhana) and Karas FM (Karas) met at the SIDA closing ceremony.
© Joseph lilonga/ UNESCO

Community radio stations in Lesotho, Namibia and South Africa that were participating in the UNESCO and Swedish International Agency (SIDA) funded project, “Empowering local radios with ICTs” have hailed the support they received since 2012 saying it made huge differences in their communities.

Speaking during different concluding workshops organised for their stations in June 2016, correspondents, journalists, news editors, finance officers, marketing officers and station managers expressed satisfaction with the impact the project had on their operations.

Radio Atlantis (South Africa) Board Chairperson who also produces and presents programmes at the Station said the project “made our presence felt in the community”.

“This project gave us the necessary skills to produce high quality programmes that are participatory in nature. As a result, community members felt our presence as evidenced by the positive feedback we keep on receiving,” he said.

Mafeteng Community Radio Station News Editor, Mr. Monosi Monosi concurred saying the project enabled them to serve their community well.

“Training on the effective use of ICTs and provision of basic equipment such as mobile phones opened windows for us to reach most of our community members -

and receive instant feedback unlike before. The feedback that we get is important as it enables us to improve our programming taking into account issues raised by the listeners,” added Mr. Sello.

He also said Mafeteng Community Radio used to struggle to raise funds and sustain its operations but the project gave them skills and ways to conquer that.

“Before this project, our station was not generating any meaningful income. We did not have marketing and financial management — **See page 22...**



Mafeteng Community Radio Station members posing for a group picture during a workshop.

Community Radio Stations hail UNESCO and Swedish support



Volunteers from Ohangwena Community Radio received a mixer donated by the UNESCO/SIDA project.

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skills. However, through this project, we have improved drastically. We can generate good income and even pay our correspondents. We have a functional marketing team and this community knows us now,” boasted Mr. Monosi.

The project built the human and technical capacities of the radio stations, established networks of news correspondents and enhanced programming quality of the participating radios. The networks of news correspondents enabled reportage of issues from the widest geographical areas covered by these stations. This ensured that most community members’ information, education and entertainment needs were met.

The project came to an end on 30 June 2016 having ran for four years. Most community radios that participated in the project did not have adequate skills to use ICTs at the beginning of the project. They also had serious sustainability challenges. Most of these challenges were addressed by the project.

Speaking at a meeting to officially mark the end of the project in Namibia, UNESCO Windhoek Office Communication and Information Programme Officer, Mr. Chimbidzikai Mapfumo urged stations to remain focussed and harness the successes achieved for the growth of their stations.

“The project is coming to an end but the results should not end,” he said. “In fact, we should multiply them on our own. Let us avoid reversing these gains,” added Mapfumo.

“We are very impressed with what you achieved through the project. Coverage of issues affecting women increased as well as health issues like HIV and AIDS. You increased coverage of humanitarian and development issues. Your marketing and financial management skills have improved. In short, you have become ideal community radios – please continue on that path”, he concluded.

Namibia Community Broadcasters Network (NCBN) Chairperson Mr. Levi Katire thanked UNESCO and SIDA for supporting the growth of community radios in Namibia and other African countries. He said NCBN itself was a tangible product of the UNESCO/SIDA project.



From left: Namibia Community Broadcasters Network (NCBN) Chairperson Mr. Levi Katire, Ms Tolerance Hanse (NCBN) and Mr Chimbidzikai Mapfumo (UNESCO).

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Invitee of the month: Ms. Ruusa Mushimba, United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) National Project Coordinator for Namibia

INVITEE OF THE MONTH



Ms Ruusa Mushimba, UNODC National Project Coordinator for Namibia. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

Our Invitee of the Month is Ms. Ruusa Mushimba, the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) National Project Coordinator For Namibia. Here is an extract of her conversation with the UNESCO Windhoek Newsletter team (UW).

UW: Thank you for agreeing to be our invitee of the month. As UNODC National Programme Officer in Namibia, what are the core policies and strategies that govern UNODC activities?

RM: Thank you for the invitation to your newsletter. Please allow me to first give an overview about UNODC. Being a global leader in the fight against illicit drugs and international crime, UNODC's mandate is to assist Member States in their struggle against illicit drugs, crime and terrorism.

Present in Namibia since 2008, UNODC provides

technical and financial support to the Namibian Government aimed at enhancing capacity as well as research on issues related to drugs and crime for evidence base and to inform policies, development of strategies and operational decisions.

Most of the interventions in Namibia are governed by four cooperative strategies; firstly, the UNODC Strategy 2012-2015; one of the thematic areas focus on Prevention, Treatment and Reintegration, and Alternative Development, focusing on HIV/AIDS prevention and care (as it relates to injecting drug use, prison settings, and trafficking in human beings).

Secondly, United Nations Partnership Framework (UNPAF) 2014-2018 which was signed between the Namibian Government and United Nations (UN). Health is one of the UNPAF pillars, UNODC is currently assisting the government in the implementation of the HIV and AIDS Prevention, Treatment, Care and Support program in Prison Settings.

Thirdly, Namibia's Fourth National Development Plan (NDP4) 2013 – 2017. Health is one of the priority areas of the plan, and UNODC interventions improve access to health services including health service delivery within prison settings, literally very much aligned to NDP4.

Fourth, Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). UNODC's work is aligned to the SDGs particularly SDG 3 which aspires to promote health and well being for all.

UW: Being part of the UN family, what are the comparative advantages of UNODC and how do you complement other Agencies' efforts?

RM: As per UNPAF, being part of the UN family means we need to leverage available resources in support of delivering as one. Most of UNODC activities complement other UN agencies efforts especially on key issues related to our mandate particularly drug and crime, health and gender. UNODC is also a member of the Joint UN Team on AIDS (JUTA) which aims to ensure the cohesion and effectiveness of the UN contribution to an expanded HIV national response in Namibia.

UW: What are some of the key success stories of UNODC in Namibia thus far?

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Invitee of the month: Ms Ruusa Mushimba, United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) National Project Coordinator for Namibia



Namibian Correctional Service Senior Managers attending a sensitization workshop on HIV and AIDS in Prison settings in Windhoek, December 2015.

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RM: One of our many successes is assisting the government to develop and implement the Namibian Correctional Service Health Policy and the Namibian Correctional Service Health Strategic Plan. The health policy was officially launched this year.

UNODC also took an initiative to improve access to health services for people incarcerated through the refurbishment of two of the Namibian Correctional Service ambulances with up to date medical equipment; this is to ensure that prisoners are safely transported to local hospitals under healthy and safe conditions.

UW: What are some of the pressing issues related to drug/substance abuse in Namibia?

RM: Drugs and alcohol abuse is increasingly being recognized in Namibia. It is very disturbing how the country has transformed from being a drug transit to a drug use country, with drug abuse being rampant among youth - especially the school going.

Drugs destroy societies and families; I would like to commend the Namibian law enforcement agents for their efforts in curbing drugs in the country. Drug trafficking itself is a dynamic but complex operation which continually evolves. Not long ago the media reported that women and children are being used as

drug mules, and many women have been reported to be locked up in foreign jails. The situation calls for joint efforts in strengthening preventive mechanisms/measures to counteract drug abuse in Namibia.

UW: Following the adoption of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) last year, can you tell us how they have impacted/will impact on your work in Namibia?

RM: Depending on which of the 17 goals and 169 targets the government prioritizes, UNODC's work will be guided and aligned to the adopted SDGs. In this regard, UNODC remains committed to supporting the government in the implementation and achievement of the SDGs.

UW: Which of the 17 SDGs are your Organization prioritizing in Namibia and why?

RM: All SDGs are equally important, however due to limited funds, we are prioritizing SDG 3 on good health and wellbeing, SDG 5 on gender equality and SDG 16 on Peace, justice and strong institutions.

UW: Namibia is now categorized as an upper-middle income country and there have been concerns by some development partners that this category will see a decline in donor support for the country. What are your views about this argument and has your Organization been affected in any way? **See page 25...**



Handing over ceremony of the refurbished ambulances to the Namibian Correctional Services, May 2016.

Invitee of the month: Ms Ruusa Mushimba, United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) National Project Coordinator for Namibia



DID YOU KNOW: It is estimated that almost a quarter of a billion people between the ages of 15 and 64 years used an illicit drug in 2013. This corresponds to a global prevalence of 5.2 per cent (range: 3.4-7.0 per cent), suggesting that drug use has remained stable in the past three years, although the estimated number of drug users has actually risen by 6 million to 246 million (range: 162 million-329 million) owing to the increase in the global population.

Source: UNODC, responses to annual report questionnaire.

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RM: The classification of Namibia as an upper-middle income country has been welcomed with mixed feelings; however they say data doesn't lie! Income per capita figures for Namibia are convincing, however the country has a significant gap of inequality and distribution of wealth remains a challenge. Because of the country's ranking, donor funding is drastically declining hence the downscaling of our activities is eminent.

UW: *There are widespread concerns about drug/substance abuse among school going children.*

What measures have UNODC put in place to sensitize children about the dangers of drug/substance abuse?

RM: UNODC is collaborating with the United Nations Information Centre (UNIC) in educating school going youth on the danger of drugs. This is done through an outreach school education program targeting school in Windhoek.

UW: *Can you please tell us which drugs/substances are the most common and easily accessible in Namibia for children?*

RM: We have limited information about the exact drugs that are accessible to children in Namibia, however a study conducted in 2015 on HIV and drug use, especially injecting drug use, among women in Namibia found that marijuana, mandrax, heroine, cocaine and methamphetamine are very common.

UW: *How does UNODC assist drug/substance abuse victims to seek counselling and rehabilitation?*

RM: Our awareness raising interventions helps people who abuse drugs to seek help. A rapid situation assessment and response study on HIV and drug use was done in 2015 to inform future programming.

UW: *In 2015, the President of the Republic of Namibia declared a war on poverty and called upon all development partners to help his government in this fight. Drug abuse is very common in impoverished communities in Namibia, What is UNODC doing to contribute to poverty eradication within the context of its mandate?*

RM: Poverty is a big challenge for Namibia at the moment. Since the new government came on board poverty has been receiving attention more than ever before. Underreported issues such as drug abuse and alcohol have emerged as a challenge. Drug abuse and poverty are actually interlinked, a person in an impoverished situation may resort to drugs and alcohol to be able deal with his or her difficult situation. In many impoverished communities drugs and alcohol are readily available. People sell drugs and alcohol to overcome their poverty. This is a complex issue and it requires a holistic approach; one cannot address drug abuse without addressing poverty as a first step. In this regard, UNODC has responded to the President's call on poverty by joining the team on poverty eradication. Awareness raising about the dangers of drug abuse is one of our key intervention in this regard.

UW: *What are some of the key opportunities for UNODC and the Namibian Government working together to control the sale and trafficking of illicit drugs into Namibia?*

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Invitee of the month: Ms Ruusa Mushimba, United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) National Project Coordinator for Namibia



School youth attending UNODC presentation during the commemoration of the International Day against Drug abuse and Illicit Trafficking June 2015.

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RM: Poverty is one of the key government priorities; since poverty is a risk factor to drug abuse UNODC is ready to support the government by providing technical expertise in the development of control measures to prevent and control illicit drugs in the country.

UW: What opportunities are there for UNESCO and UNODC to work together in Namibia?

RM: Drug abuse is a problem among school going youth, therefore UNODC and UNESCO can work together in advocating and developing a module on illicit drug use in any of the school health curriculums. There are many more opportunities, for example using media platforms to educate students about the dangers of drugs.

UW: For every successful tall tree there is a beginning. Can you tell us a bit about your professional career and how you ended up in this position?

RM: I am born and bred in Namibia, after I completed my tertiary education at the University of Namibia; I continued to study with the University of Lancaster in the United Kingdom for a Master Degree in Health Research. I have been working in the health field for more than two decades now. I worked for few International Organizations before I joined United Nations.

UW: To us you are known as the UNODC National Programme Officer in Namibia, but please tell us who Ms Ruusa Mushimba is besides the title of leadership she holds?

RM: I regard myself as a peoples servant and a voice of the voiceless. My transformational leadership style finds opportunities out of every situation, and inspires others to achieve desired change. I'm happy to say my work brings me so much joy and fulfilment knowing that somewhere on this planet earth I have improved/contributed to someone's wellbeing in whatever small way.

UW: What are your hobbies?

RM: Beside music, I like playing golf during my spare time. This helps me to take my mind off everything so that I can have a conversation with myself.

UW: What really makes you tick (interest)?

RM: Anything that challenges me intellectually will keep me glued!

UW: How do you deal with challenges and balancing between your demanding work and the family?

RM: A challenge for me is an opportunity for growth, my work is very challenging but that's what I like about it as it keeps me on my toes. I always find time for myself after work and on weekends to see friends and family members.

UW: Tell us about your parents and siblings. Did they have any influence on the person you are today? And who inspired you most in life?

RM: My father is deceased, but I'm lucky to have a mother who is my big pillar of strength. I have two elder sisters and I'm the youngest. I'm from a big extended family of uncles, aunties, cousins, nephews and nieces and we help each other so much as a family.

UW: We have come to the end of our interview, thank you for sharing your time with us. However, before we say goodbye, what advice, quote or words of inspiration would you like to share with our readers?

RM: Current pressing issues in Namibia need joint efforts from almost everyone. Everyone's contribution counts and makes a difference. "Alone we can do so little; together we can do so much" - *Helen Keller*

Highlights of the Month



Mr. Chimbizikai Mapfumo, former Head of Communication and Information at UNESCO receiving a thank you gift from staff members during his Farewell party. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO



Mr. Chimbizikai Mapfumo interacting with his colleagues on his final day at the office. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO



Members of the UNESCO Scoping Mission and the United Nations Country Team (UNCT). © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO



(Left) Ms. Dennia Gayle and Prof. Dr. Quazi Monirul Islam (Middle) at the school drop-out and out-of-school children conference.



(Right) Mr. Jerry Beukes sharing his views about TVET during the UNESCO Scoping Mission validation workshop in Windhoek. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO



Ms. Alka Bhatia briefing the media on how to report about the SDG's during a joint workshop between UNDP and UNESCO. © Joseph lilonga/UNESCO

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